ENTERTAINMENT

GAME CHANGER

On stand-up comic **Samay Raina's** *YouTube channel, his fellow comedians take on chess grandmasters*

In 2019, Samay Raina, 21, jointly won the second season of *Comicstaan*, Amazon Prime Video's popular standup reality competition. In 2020, he won the internet.

As the surge of a deadly pandemic halted lives—erasing any possibility of stage time for stand-up comedians across the globe—Raina started a YouTube channel. To play chess. He live-streamed the games, pairing Indian comedians opposite grandmasters like Vidit Gurajthi, Vishwanathan Anand and Teimour Radjabov. It was a sort of online chess tournament that gave an unlikely makeover to the reputation of the sport. "The perception about chess has always been that chess players are boring or strict," says Raina, an avid chess enthusiast. "I don't think Indians ever got a chance to see how fun chess can be. Everyone thinks of it only as a game of intelligence." The comedian's livestreams didn't only make the game more accessible to the public, they also changed the general assumptions about the game once "people got a chance to interact with grandmasters". The success rate of Raina's chess experiment is evident in his digital ascension: in under a year, his YouTube channel has grossed over 835,000 subscribers, and hundreds of people log in daily to watch his livestreams.

Raina doesn't seem surprised. For him, stand-up and the world of online streaming aren't much different. "In stand-up, when you crack a good joke, you get a laugh. On streaming, you crack a joke and get a laugh emoji," Raina says. "No one needs to buy a ticket or travel to see you, so the pressure to come prepared with jokes is a lot less."

By his own admission, live-streaming for an entire year has helped free him as a comedian. "The few times that I got to perform on stage when things had opened up, I felt more chilled out." Still, he admits that all of it is moot if a comedian isn't authentic. "You can write 5-10 minutes of material as someone you want to be. But that's about it. Real comedy comes from the place of being true to yourself."

In Raina's case, that has meant carving out a distinct voice. His brand of observational comedy is sharp and economical. Even then, being a stand-up comedian is never easy. For one, the metrics of success are never the same. "It doesn't necessarily mean that just because you're a good comedian, you'll be guaranteed a streaming audience. Or that if you're a good streamer, you will have people buying tickets to the show," he says. It says something that Raina is possibly one of the few Indian comedians who has managed the feat of ensuring people come to his show as well as tune into his live streams. "I'm in a happy place," he says. ■

–Poulomi Das

